THE STUDY-TO-WORK GUIDE

FROM EDUCATION TO ECONOMIC IMPACT

For international master's students aiming at Germany and Canada

ECHEZONA SAMUEL MGBECHETA

Guide + templates + budget workbook · 2026 edition

From Education to Economic Impact

The Study-to-Work Guide for International Master's Students Aiming at Germany and Canada

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IMPORTANT

This book is general information for planning. It is not legal, immigration, tax, financial or medical advice, and nobody can promise you admission, funding, a visa, a permit or a job. Rules, fees and thresholds change often. The figures in this edition were collected from official and other published sources in October 2026. Confirm every figure on the official page before you rely on it, and ask a qualified adviser about your own case.

Names of organisations, programmes and products belong to their owners and are used only to describe them. The author has no commercial link to any insurer, bank or service named in this book.

Start here

What you will get: a plan for the whole journey, not just the visa. It is written for international master's students aiming at Germany or Canada who want to work there after graduating. You will learn how to choose a programme with the job market in mind, win scholarships and campus jobs, budget for Germany or Canada, pass the visa and permit steps, build a route from study to work, and get hired.

What is in your package

1. **This book**
   The full guide, from first application to first job in Germany or Canada.
2. **Application Template Pack** (Word)
   Ten editable templates: CV, motivation letter, emails, arrival card, rental letter and more.
3. **Budget and Application Tracker** (Excel)
   Fourteen sheets: budgets, timeline, return-on-investment calculator, Opportunity Card points, payroll deductions, fact-check log.
4. **Settling In** (companion guide, PDF)
   Housing, paperwork, health insurance, money, your first semester and wellbeing.

How to use it

- **Short on time?** Read "Your first seven days" in How This Book Is Organised, then go to the chapter you need.
- **Use the tools as you read.** Each chapter names the template or sheet that goes with it.
- **Check every figure before you act.** Fees, thresholds and rules change. The Appendix lists the official page for each key figure, with space for your own check date.

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How This Book Is Organised

This book is for international master's students who want to study in Germany or Canada and then work there after graduating, whether you are still at home planning your move or already abroad. Germany and Canada are the worked examples because those are the two systems I know first-hand, and the method applies to other destinations as well. Use this guide to find the chapters you need most.

Chapters 1 to 3 (Part I) look at how education drives growth, how teaching builds mastery and leadership, and how to build academic strength in economics and related fields.

Chapters 4 to 6 (Part II) describe the hidden struggles of international students and immigrants, show how to turn academic research into real exposure and opportunity, and explain why universities, research centres and industry need to work together.

Chapters 7 to 9 (Part III) explain how high-value skills can earn you a living across borders, why you should be open to mentorship, and how to prepare a strong scholarship application, including a motivation letter.

Chapters 10 to 12 (Part IV) give you the practical tools: a European-style CV, interview preparation, a monthly budget (with Germany as the example), a 12-month application timeline and a visa and relocation checklist.

Chapters 13 to 15 (Part V) treat studying and working as one journey. They show how to choose a degree with the job market in mind, which routes lead from study to work in Germany and Canada, how to earn while you study within the legal limits, and what to do in your first 30 days.

Chapters 16 to 20 (Part VI) cover the part many guides skip: how to actually get hired in Germany and Canada, what your salary will be after deductions, how to get your degree recognised, the self-employment route, and a one-page comparison with the Netherlands, Ireland and France.

Your first seven days

If you want to start today, do one step a day:

- **Day 1:** Decide your destination, your level (Bachelor's, Master's or PhD) and your field.
- **Day 2:** List three to six programmes in the Application Tracker, with their deadlines and language requirements.
- **Day 3:** Check which language test you need and look at test dates.
- **Day 4:** Gather your documents: passport, transcripts, certificates and translations.
- **Day 5:** Write your CV with Template 1 in the Application Template Pack.

CHAPTER 11

Financial Planning for International Students

Money decides whether you can stay and finish. Good planning reduces stress and protects your studies.

Proof of funds comes first

Most countries ask you to prove that you can pay for your living costs. For a German student visa, the usual route is a blocked account (Sperrkonto). For 2026 the standard required amount is €11,904 for one year, which is €992 per month, and you can withdraw only that monthly amount after you arrive. Applicants for some other visa types, such as the Opportunity Card, may need a higher amount. The government adjusts these figures from time to time, so confirm the exact amount with the German mission that handles your visa before you transfer any money. Canada has its own rules, set out in the Canada section below, and other countries have theirs, so check the official immigration website of your destination.

Example monthly student budget in Germany

These are indicative ranges for planning. Real costs depend on the city, your housing type and your lifestyle, and they change, so replace them with figures you have checked.

- **Accommodation:** roughly €350 to €600, with student dormitories usually at the lower end and private rooms in large cities at the higher end
- **Health insurance:** roughly €140 to €150 per month for statutory student cover in 2026 if you are under 30, and much more after 30; confirm with the insurer
- **Food:** roughly €200 to €280
- **Transport:** often covered by the semester ticket that comes with your semester contribution (a fee of roughly €150 to €400 per semester at many universities)
- **Phone and internet:** roughly €20 to €40
- **Study materials:** roughly €20 to €50
- **Personal costs and leisure:** roughly €50 to €100
- **Emergency savings:** a fixed amount every month, even a small one

Add these up for your own city and compare the total with the monthly amount your blocked account releases. If the budget does not fit, you have three choices: cheaper housing, a part-time job within the legal work limits, or a scholarship. Check the current rules on student work with your university and the

official Make it in Germany website.

Be careful with fees as well. Besides tuition (many public universities in Germany charge none for most programmes, but some states and private universities do), count the visa fee, the application fees, document translation and certification, flights, and the first month's deposit for housing.

Canada: proof of funds and monthly budget

For a Canadian study permit application submitted on or after 1 September 2026, a single applicant studying outside Quebec must show at least CAD 23,448 for first-year living costs, in addition to first-year tuition and travel costs (SFU International Student Advising, 31 August 2026). The amount that applies is the one in force on the date you submit your application. It was CAD 22,895 for applications submitted from 1 September 2025 to 31 August 2026, and Canada updates it every year, so check the current figure on the IRCC proof of financial support page before you apply.

- **What you must show:** one year of tuition, the minimum living-cost amount above, and your travel costs to and from Canada.
- **How the officer judges it:** your funds must be readily available and not depend on future employment in Canada, and it must be reasonable to expect that funding continues for the later years of your programme.
- **Who it applies to:** new study permit applicants and students who extend their permit from inside Canada.
- **Quebec:** it has its own financial requirement and its own provincial approval, the CAQ, so check the Quebec government and your university.
- **Family members:** the amount rises with each person who comes with you, so use the table on the IRCC page.

IRCC lists the documents it accepts as proof, such as bank statements and a letter from the person or organisation paying for you. Use the current list on canada.ca, and be ready to show where the money came from. Sums that appear suddenly in your account without explanation are a common cause of refusal.

Monthly budget planning for Canada

The living-cost minimum works out to about CAD 1,954 per month (CAD 23,448 divided by 12). That is the minimum IRCC asks you to show, not a promise that it covers your real costs. Rent in large cities can take a large share of it. Use these lines and fill in figures from your university's international student cost page and from listings in your city:

- **Accommodation:** residence, shared house or private rental; ask your university for typical local prices
- **Health insurance:** depends on the province and the university, since some provinces include students in their health plan and others require private or university insurance

- **Food:** groceries and some meals out
- **Transport:** monthly pass or student transit pass
- **Phone and internet:** a local plan
- **Winter clothing and study materials:** a one-time cost at the start
- **Personal costs and emergency savings:** a fixed amount every month

Working while you study. Full-time students at a designated learning institution can generally work off campus up to 24 hours per week during academic sessions, and full-time during scheduled breaks, if their study permit allows it. Rules and conditions change, so read the conditions printed on your own permit and never work more hours than they allow, because breaking them can cost you your status.

Emergency savings strategy

- Aim to build a reserve equal to at least one to three months of living costs.
- Pay yourself first: move a fixed amount into a separate savings account on the day money arrives.
- Keep the reserve apart from your daily account so you do not spend it by accident.
- Keep a small amount in your home currency and a small amount in the local currency, to handle exchange-rate surprises.

Cost management tools

- A simple spreadsheet with columns for date, category, amount and note
- A free budgeting app that tracks spending by category
- Student discounts and the semester ticket
- Cooking at home and buying second-hand books and furniture
- A monthly review: compare what you planned with what you spent, and adjust